

We can even imagine a **utility monster**, who simply gets more pleasure out of everything than anyone else does. When faced with a choice between giving some good to the utility monster or giving that good to someone else, what does utilitarianism say to do?

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We can even imagine a utility monitor, which simply gets more

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What is justice?

ask what it means for a person to be just. We can also ask what it

Today we are going to focus on the question of what it means for

an individual society → which for our purposes we can take to be a

This question breaks down into a number of sub-questions. We can

mean for an international system of distinct societies to be just.

nation -- to be just.

This question is sometimes called the question of distributive

justice, because it asks about the just distribution of goods within

a society at a time.

What goods are we talking about?

things like food and property and income.

One category is what we might call material goods. These include

rights (such as the right to vote) and liberties (such as the

freedom to choose where one lives or whom one marries or what job

But these are not the only goods. Other goods include political

one pursues). As we will see, there are others.

This is enough to describe a society which most of us would agree

to be unjust.



At some initial time t , the members of a society are living in a state of

freedom to pursue an education). By time $t+2$, group A owns all the

enslaved the members of group B, depriving them by force of their

the property of subgroup B . Group A consolidates its power, and

property, and gives members of group B only the are minimized

relative quality. But at later time $t+1$, sub-group A takes all of

in the ways that members of group A direct.

for survival. Members of group B are only permitted to serve group A

political rights and liberties (such as freedom of association and the

It is universal that, at $t+2$, this is an unjust society.

answers to this question.

for this to be a just society? Different theories of justice provide different

The interesting question is: why is this? What would have to be different

inequality. On this view, a just society is one in which goods are

question. On this view, what is unjust about our imagined society is its

distributed equally. This view is egalitarianism.

Our first theory of justice provides a very straightforward answer to this

answer would be that everyone gets exactly the same goods. Everyone

What would it mean for goods to be distributed equally? A simple

get the same food, just the same kind of residence, etc.

our simplest egalitarian view.

more spinach and less broccoli? And yet this would seem to be unjust on

better for me to get more brocoli and less spinach, and for you to get

love and hate spin each, and you are the reverse. Wouldn't it be

But if you think about it, this wouldn't be an ideal set-up. Suppose that

an equal distribution of goods need not mean that we each get exactly

The fact that we made different choices would not make the distribution

we would each get the same amount of money and the same income.

The natural response to this on behalf of the egalitarian is to say that

opportunity to buy goods. In a society like ours, this would mean that

could then use this money on broccoli, and you could use it on spinach.

the same goods. Instead, perhaps we each should get exactly the same

of goods unequal.

A second problem for the egalitarian is the problem of how to handle

inequalities that emerge over time.

Even if we specify that you and I get the same income at every period in

clever with yours, so that after 20 years you have accumulated large

and yours was not.

might be very wasteful with my resources where a might be very

lives, we might still end up with very unequal distribution of goods.

amount of resources. Or maybe my house was destroyed by a tornado,

It's like, at the end of this 20 year period, we might have a very

there a non-trivial distribution of resources to restore equality?

unequal distribution of resources. This leads to a dilemma for the

egalitarian. Should we simply permit this kind of inequality, or should